

Narrative Crossroads: Romeo and Juliet

A character analysis framework for exploring key decisions and motivations

Overview

This module adapts the Narrative Crossroads framework for analyzing Shakespeare’s “Romeo and Juliet.” Students write in character as characters at pivotal moments in the play, exploring motivations and decisions that shape the tragic narrative.

Setting Context

- **Time Period:** Renaissance Italy (14th–15th century)
 - **Location:** Verona, Italy
 - **Social Context:** Rigid social hierarchy, family honor, arranged marriages
 - **Atmosphere:** Passionate, violent, fatalistic
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Character Options

Choose, or roll a die.

Roll	Character	What they want	What they fear
1–2	Romeo	Juliet, immediately and completely	Being kept from her
3–4	Juliet	A life she has chosen rather than been assigned	Waking alone in the tomb
5	Mercutio	The joke, the last word, his friend’s honour	Being taken for nothing
6	Friar Lawrence	Peace between the houses, by his own cleverness	That the plan will come apart in his hands

Threshold Moments

Choose, or roll a die. Everyone works the same moment.

Roll	Threshold Moment	Why it is a threshold
1–2	The Balcony Scene	Deciding to pursue the relationship; and Planning future communications
3–4	The Fight Scene (Mercutio / Tybalt)	Responding to Tybalt's challenge; and Choosing between revenge and restraint
5–6	Before Taking the Potion	Weighing risks of the Friar's plan; and Deciding to follow through

The Three Lenses

Everyone works from the same character at the same threshold moment. Each student takes one lens — pick, or roll a die so the room spreads across all three. The die only chooses the way in; nothing is rolled against a character, and there is nothing to succeed or fail at.

Roll	Lens	What it asks at this moment
1–2	Confrontation	A clash. What are you up against, and what does facing it cost?
3–4	Comprehension	A realization. What do you understand now that you didn't a moment ago?
5–6	Connection	The bonds. Who is this really about, and what do you owe them?

Then write a few sentences in the character's voice, at that moment, showing one thing from the character's wants or fears. The writing is the play.

Thematic Elements

- The conflict between love and family loyalty
- Fate versus free will
- The consequences of impulsive decisions
- The role of authority figures
- The nature of true love

Implementation Guide

Classroom Setup (45–60 minutes)

1. **Introduction (5 min):** Explain the round and distribute cards
2. **Character Selection (5 min):** Students choose a character, or roll a die for one
3. **Threshold Moment (5 min):** The teacher frames one moment for the whole room
4. **Evidence (10 min):** Students fill the Character Frame — what this character wants and fears, with a line or page number
5. **Take a lens and write (15–20 min):** Students take a lens and write in character

6. **Harvest (10–15 min):** Read several aloud, at least one per lens, then ask which reading the text supports

Materials Needed

- A die per table, if you want to assign lenses by chance rather than choice. It is optional; students can simply pick.
- Character Frame cards
- Copy of the text

Assessment Options

- **Character Journal:** Students submit written responses from the character's perspective
- **Dramatic Monologue:** Students perform their character's internal thoughts at the threshold moment
- **Comparative Analysis:** Students analyze how different characters approach similar dilemmas
- **Alternate Timeline:** Students explore how different decisions might have altered the tragic outcome

ELA Standards Alignment

- **RL.9-10.2** — Determine a theme and analyze in detail its development over the course of the text
- **RL.9-10.3** — Analyze how complex characters develop, interact with other characters, and advance the plot
- **RL.9-10.5** — Analyze how an author's choices concerning structure create effects such as tension or surprise
- **SL.9-10.1** — Initiate and participate effectively in collaborative discussions

Sample Response

Character: Juliet

Threshold Moment: Before Taking the Potion — the moment when Juliet must decide whether to drink the Friar's potion.

Lens: Comprehension

What they wrote:

As you hold the vial in your trembling hand, your mind races through all possibilities. What if the potion is actually poison? What if you wake too early—or too late? What if Romeo never receives Friar Lawrence's message? Yet your analytical mind cuts through the fear. You understand that despite these risks, the alternative—marriage to Paris while already wed to Romeo—is impossible. Your comprehension of the Friar's character also reassures you; he has been trustworthy thus far, and his plan, though desperate, is sound. With clarity amidst your fear, you raise the vial to your lips. 'Love give me strength,' you whisper, 'and strength shall help afford.' You drink, choosing temporary isolation with the promise of reunion over a life of divided loyalties.

Version 3

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